POLSC 343: American Foreign Policy

Study Guide—Exam 2: Actors and Institutions

Covers: Congress and the Presidency · The Policymaking Process · The Bureaucracy and the State Department · The Defense Department and the Military

How to Use This Guide

Exam 2 is a closed-book, closed-note, in-class exam on the actors and institutions material. This guide covers the four lectures named above and their assigned readings.

The organizing move of this unit is different from Exam 1. The historical unit asked what happened and why; this one asks who decides, through what institutional machinery, and with what predictable failures. Nearly every section answers one of three questions: where does the power formally sit, who actually exercises it, and what goes wrong. Keep those three columns in mind as you read.

> Four questions that run through the whole unit: (1) Where do institutions give Congress and the president shared, rather than separated, powers—and why does that distinction matter? (2) Why do capable people following reasonable organizational mandates still produce bad policy? (3) How does formal position in a hierarchy differ from actual influence? (4) In what sense is the military a political institution, and what is the difference between non-political and non-partisan?

1. Congress and the Presidency

1.1 The Traditional View—and Why It Is Wrong

Traditional claim about the President	Traditional claim about Congress
Enjoys primacy in foreign policymaking	Unimportant in foreign policymaking
Elected by one "district"—the whole country	An agglomeration of narrow views
Therefore represents the national interest	Legislators represent narrow constituencies

The lecture presents this view in order to reject it. The corrections:

- Many members of Congress are active in foreign policymaking and care intensely about specific issues—defense, trade, human rights.
- Presidents do not serve the whole country. Count the share of the population actually responsible for electing a president and the "national constituency" claim erodes quickly. Recall the Exam 1 material: the Northeast held a lock on the presidency for years and advanced policies other regions openly opposed.
- The electorate is not one mass. Some voters are dedicated partisans who vote the party line regardless; much smaller segments actually attend to and try to influence specific policy issues.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> Notice that this is the same analytical move as the Exam 1 bipartisanship material: take a claim about institutions acting in the national interest and replace it with a claim about which specific coalitions hold power.

1.2 Institutions Do Not Fight

Press and textbook accounts describe Congress and the president as "conflicting institutions." The lecture calls this wrong on its face:

- Institutions are the rules governing how we govern. They determine who holds which powers and when, and how power is allocated.
- Institutions have no preferences. Only actors have preferences.
- What we observe as institutional conflict is partisans using the levers of power available to them to influence outcomes and curb opponents.
- Those conflicts cluster predictably: during divided government, and often immediately following wars—World War I, World War II, and the post-Vietnam period are the lecture's examples.

> The Constitutional Convention did not create a system of separated powers—it created a government of separated institutions sharing powers.—Richard Neustadt

- The payoff of Neustadt's formulation: Congress holds some powers over foreign policy and so do presidents; both can influence the military. The president is commander in chief, but of an impoverished military if Congress does not appropriate funds.
- This reframes congressional inaction. When Congress does not act, that is the result of politics—not an absence of institutionally endowed power.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> This is the single most important idea in the lecture and the most likely essay prompt. If you find yourself writing "Congress lost its war powers," ask whether you mean Congress was stripped of authority or chose not to use it. The lecture insists on the second.

1.3 Appointments

- Appointments matter in two areas: the foreign policy bureaucracy (Secretary of State, Secretary of Defense, and similar posts, all subject to Senate confirmation) and the Executive Office of the President.
- The EOP was created in 1939 in response to growing demands on the executive branch. The New Deal and then World War II drove massive growth in the federal bureaucracy.
- Before FDR, presidents had no legal authority to create new positions. FDR relied on a series of advisers he could not lawfully employ, and used vacant cabinet posts as workarounds.
- The crucial asymmetry: EOP positions are not subject to congressional approval. The National Security Adviser is the key case.
- Consequence: presidents increasingly rely on chiefs of staff, senior advisers, and National Security Advisers rather than on Senate-confirmed cabinet officers. This gives presidents more control, lets them evade congressional oversight, and centralizes policymaking in the White House—at the expense of the Secretary of State in particular.

The scale of the executive branch

- The executive branch dwarfs the other two. It needs large numbers of people to implement policy, which also gives it a very deep bench of expertise. Congress and the courts have nothing comparable in budget or personnel.
- Executive employment grows steadily from the 1940s across nearly every department. DoD accounts for the overwhelming bulk of it—and that figure does not include active duty military personnel.

- State Department employment skyrockets with World War II. But even after that growth, State remains tiny next to DoD.

Contested confirmations

- Most appointments clear the Senate. Most that would fail never reach a vote—the nominee usually withdraws first, which is a selection effect you should be able to name.
- Charles Bohlen (1953), Ambassador to the USSR, succeeding Kennan after Stalin declared Kennan persona non grata. Confirmed 74–13 despite being targeted by Joseph McCarthy. Note that this is simultaneously the height of "bipartisanship" and the height of McCarthyism.
- John Tower (1989), G.H.W. Bush's nominee for Defense. Rejected—a genuine rarity—over his reputation as a heavy drinker.
- Pete Hegseth (2025), Defense. Confirmed 51–50, with three Republicans and two independents joining 45 Democrats in opposition and Vice President Vance casting the tie-breaking vote. He lacked policy-level experience and faced allegations of sexual assault, abuse, and financial mismanagement.
- The comparison that makes the point: Even during recent years and with significant background polarization, Lloyd Austin was confirmed 93–2, and James Mattis 98–1.
- Secretary of State Marco Rubio also confirmed with strong majority.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> The lecture asks you to explain the Hegseth–Austin–Mattis contrast using the Exam 1 toolkit: fewer moderates, rising polarization, the changing composition of the Senate, and changes in selection and vetting. Be ready to argue which does the most work.

Impeachment of cabinet officers

- In addition to vetting and approving appointments, Congress can move to impeach cabinet secretaries, not just presidents. The power is in Article II, Section 4.
- In spring 2026 nine House Democrats attempted to impeach Secretary Hegseth; in September 2026 Representative Thomas Massie (R-KY) moved to impeach him.
- The charges stem from the Iran War, the Caribbean boat strikes, suppression of free speech, and mishandling of classified evidence—with particular focus on the missile strike on an Iranian girls' school and "double tap" strikes on boats in the Caribbean.
- "Double tap" means launching a second strike to kill survivors of the first. This violates international law because the targets are non-combatants and are unable to continue the fight.
- The school strike (February 28, 2026): two US Tomahawk missiles hit Shajareh Tayyebeh primary school, killing 156 civilians including 123 children. A UN report confirmed US responsibility.

> The causes investigators identified in the school strike are a compact case study in everything this unit covers: commanders compressing more than 1,000 targets into 24 hours to comply with presidential orders; outdated targeting intelligence (analysts flagged the site as a school as early as 2019, but the warning never reached the primary targeting database); cuts to civilian harm reduction personnel; and over-reliance on AI target selection through Palantir's Maven system, whose underlying data no one verified.

1.4 International Agreements

Instrument	Who acts	Threshold	Binding?
Treaty	Executive negotiates; Senate consents; President ratifies	Two-thirds of senators present	Yes
Sole executive agreement	President or executive agents alone	None—enters force on signature	Yes, in practice
Congressional-executive agreement	President negotiates; Congress approves by joint resolution	Simple majority of both chambers	Yes
Political agreement (e.g., JCPOA)	Executive and foreign parties	None	Not legally binding

Treaties—the details that get tested

- Article II, Section 2 sets the two-thirds threshold. That is a high barrier.
- Article I, Section 10 bars states from entering treaties. Treaty-making is purely a power of the federal government.
- The president ratifies the treaty. The Senate only consents, possibly with reservations and amendments. Getting this backwards is a common error.
- Most treaties that reach a vote receive consent—another selection effect, exactly like appointments. Only agreements the Senate will approve are likely to be brought forward and put up for an actual vote.
- The House is involved indirectly but materially: it must appropriate the funds to implement a treaty, which makes its consent implicitly necessary.

Executive agreements

- Sole executive agreements, which involve Congress not at all, are relatively rare.
- Congressional-executive agreements require only majority support, and often rest on prior congressional delegation of authority.
- These do not require two-thirds Senate approval but can be just as binding, because reputational costs attach to breaking commitments.

Three cases to know

- Reciprocal Trade Agreements Act of 1934. Congress had controlled tariff levels; it delegated that authority to the executive, letting Secretary of State Cordell Hull negotiate reductions of up to 50% in exchange for reciprocal cuts. Congressional votes were limited to up or down, with no amendments—"fast track." Critically, this resulted from the changing interests of Republicans and Democrats in Congress, not from Congress deciding as a body to delegate or from an assessment of the national interest.
- SALT I and the ABM Treaty. Soviet ICBM and anti-ballistic missile construction in the 1960s raised fears of Soviet first-strike capability. Johnson opened negotiations in 1967; formal talks began under Nixon in 1969. The ABM Treaty limited each side to 200 interceptors and two missile defense sites. The SALT agreement capped offensive missiles at 1,600 for the USSR and 1,054 for the US—the US accepted lower numbers because it had better technology and more MIRVs—and froze new offensive deployments for five years as an executive agreement subject to House and Senate approval.
- The JCPOA (Iran Nuclear Deal). Concluded July 14, 2015 between Iran and the P5+1, implemented January 16, 2016, endorsed by the UN Security Council. It limited enrichment, required removal of 98% of the uranium

stockpile, restricted facilities, technology acquisition and R&D, required disassembly of equipment, and established IAEA inspection and surveillance.

> What the JCPOA actually was is the exam-worthy point. In a letter to Mike Pompeo, Assistant Secretary of State Julia Frifield wrote that it "is not a treaty or an executive agreement, and is not a signed document," but "reflects political commitments" among the parties. It is not legally binding—and it was never even signed.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> Arrange the four instruments on a spectrum from most to least constrained by Congress, then ask what a president gains and loses at each step. More flexibility buys less durability: an unsigned political commitment can be abandoned by the next administration, which is exactly what happened in 2018.

1.5 War and the Use of Force

The president enjoys four advantages:

1. Institutional powers as Commander in Chief.
2. First-mover advantage—forces can be deployed without prior authorization, leaving Congress to react. Jefferson sending Marines against the Barbary pirates is the founding-era example.
3. Information asymmetries—military and DoD officials report to the president through the chain of command, so the executive sees information first and then briefs Congress.
4. Technological change—In more recent years the advent of technology like drones, cruise missiles, and related tools allow the executive to initiate the use of military force with lower cost and possibly lower risks of escalation than in the past. Formerly, deploying actual military personnel was required.

Gulf of Tonkin (1964)

- The Tonkin Gulf Resolution passed August 7, 1964, granting broad discretionary authority to protect American interests in Southeast Asia.
- It followed alleged attacks on two US warships gathering intelligence off Vietnam. The first attack brought no military response, only a warning; a second series of attacks came days later.
- The Johnson administration used the episode to build domestic support and secure authority to escalate. This marks the real buildup in Vietnam, peaking around 540,000 US troops.
- The lesson the lecture draws: by the time Congress turned against the war, reining in executive action was extremely difficult—the Nixon administration went on to conduct a secret war in Cambodia and Laos.

The AUMFs

- 2001 AUMF, drafted after September 11. Section 2(a) authorizes "all necessary and appropriate force against those nations, organizations, or persons he determines planned, authorized, committed, or aided" the attacks, "or harbored such organizations or persons," to prevent future acts of international terrorism by them.
- 2002 AUMF (Iraq). Expresses support for enforcing UN Security Council resolutions on Iraq and pressing the Council to secure compliance, grants broad authority to use force, and ties back to the 2001 AUMF's September 11 language.
- Both have justified operations in dozens of countries under three presidents. Prominent examples: 2014 operations against ISIS in Iraq and Syria; 2016 operations against al-Shabab in Somalia; the 2019 killing of Maj. Gen. Qasem Soleimani.

- The pattern of legal justification shifts: the Bush administration leaned on the 2001 AUMF early, then relied almost exclusively on constitutional powers in its second term; Obama leaned more heavily and directly on the 2001 AUMF. Exclusive reliance on the 2002 AUMF is rare.

War Powers Resolution of 1973

- Requires consultation with Congress "in every possible instance" before deploying troops.
- Requires a report to Congress within 48 hours explaining the cause and justification for a deployment.
- Imposes time limits: authorization must be obtained within 60 days (90 if troops are in danger) or withdrawal is mandatory.
- Empowers Congress to end deployments by concurrent resolution—by majority vote, not subject to veto.
- It was intended to rein in the "imperial presidency." The president may still use force without a declaration to protect US territory and forces abroad and to rescue citizens.
- Current application: the lecture notes votes under the War Powers Resolution to end the Iran war. Know the mechanism—a concurrent resolution directing removal of forces—and why passage in one chamber, or even both, does not by itself end a deployment.

> The problem with the Act: it is rarely invoked and has never been enforced. It produces negotiation instead. Congress threatened action over troops in Lebanon in 1982 and settled for withdrawal within 18 months; similar compromises followed over Somalia in 1994 and Bosnia in 1995. No president has ever conceded being bound by it. In 1995 James Baker, testifying before the House International Relations Committee just after Republicans took Congress under a Democratic president, urged them to resist meddling because presidents need flexibility—a useful illustration that these positions often track partisan position, not principle.

1.6 What Congress Actually Has

- Tenure and committee assignments, which let legislators build real expertise over long careers.
- Legislative and budgetary powers—control of the purse reaches a wide range of foreign policy.
- Issue linkage: Congress may not cut funding for a deployment, but it can cut spending on other things the president wants.
- Oversight powers: Congress can conduct investigations, call witnesses, get expert testimony, etc., all to build a case against ongoing or new uses of military force.
- Approval of appointments. Presidents sometimes compensate for opposition by making bipartisan appointments, pulling executive policy toward legislators' preferences.
- Public outreach—members go on television, rally opposition, and raise awareness of executive action.
- Measurable effects: Studies show that divided government and congressional control correlate with a lower likelihood of using military force and with shorter deployments.
- And yet: recent years show declining congressional activity and oversight in foreign and defense policy, part of a general decline across the whole postwar period. The lecture is emphatic that this is a choice—members and party leaders have ceded ground to the executive while their official powers remain intact.

Congress acting on its own in foreign policy

- March 3, 2015: Speaker John Boehner invited Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu to address a joint session on Iran without consulting the White House or State Department. Critics saw an attempt to undermine Obama's foreign policy and to boost Netanyahu before Israeli elections weeks later.

- 2015: Senator Tom Cotton's open letter from Republican senators to Iranian leadership, read as an attempt to undermine the nuclear negotiations.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> Hold these two episodes against Section 1.6's list. Congress has substantial formal tools it declines to use, while individual members pursue freelance foreign policy that carries no legal force. What does that combination suggest about what members are actually seeking? Can unofficial efforts serve to accomplish the same ends as official efforts? How might media appearances function in ways similar to official hearings?

2. The Policymaking Process

2.1 Policy versus Decision

> Policy: plans for broad classes of future contingencies. Decision: choices for dealing with immediate problems.

	Policy	Decision
Audience	Broad—domestic supporters, party activists	Narrow—a small group of officials
Time horizon	Long; often set for an administration	Short; immediate
Driving factors	Political goals and coalition maintenance	Cognitive and psychological factors; individual personalities
Typical form	Often vague, leaving implementation open	Specific and consequential

- Because policy is often vague, how a president chooses to implement it becomes the realm of decision.
- In decision-making, policymakers often exaggerate an enemy's potential, and analogies get invoked to guide choices.
- Small groups make decision-making easier but let individual personalities matter more. Example: William Bundy's memo on getting out of Vietnam, seen by only a small group before being squashed—Daniel Ellsberg, who later leaked the Pentagon Papers, saw a copy.

The worked examples

- Decision: the bin Laden raid, May 1, 2011. Officials had to decide whether to capture or kill, and whether to release photographs of the body. Robert Gates has said a major factor against release was that the photos could be doctored, inflaming tensions and endangering US forces and diplomatic personnel around the world.
- Policy: Marshall's 1947 Harvard commencement address, which set the stage for the Marshall Plan and for US policy more broadly.
- Policy shaping decision: Eisenhower's "New Look." Eisenhower wanted to meet Cold War demands while protecting the economy, and nuclear weapons offered cheap deterrence—but through massive retaliation.
- The New Look's problems were obvious: salami tactics (would the US really answer small incursions with full nuclear force?); nuclear weapons could destroy the very thing being protected; and covert operations were often too small to matter. The middle ground between small fights and full nuclear war was left largely open.

2.2 How Policy Constrains Decision

- Rumsfeld in Kuwait, December 8, 2004. Asked by Army Spc. Thomas Wilson why soldiers were digging through landfills for scrap metal to armor their vehicles, Rumsfeld answered: "you go to war with the army you have, not the army you might want or wish to have at a later time."
- The leaner force was a product of Bush administration priorities. The administration campaigned on lower taxes and against nation-building, and wanted a lighter, more agile military with less emphasis on heavy infantry and mechanized units.
- The 2002 National Security Strategy called for transforming a military built to deter Cold War armies toward how an adversary might fight rather than where and when. Rumsfeld's 2001 Foreign Affairs article and the 2001 Quadrennial Defense Review abandoned the two-front war doctrine in favor of deterring multiple aggressors while retaining the ability to occupy one.
- The constraint bit when the US tried to occupy and rebuild two countries. The policy was not necessarily wrong, but it tied the administration's hands with respect to what they could do later. They had to deal with the constraints their own policies had put into place.
- Trump and the JCPOA. Campaigning so heavily on opposition to the deal limited his ability to keep it or to renegotiate better terms, against the recommendations of members of his own national security team, like Secretary of Defense James Mattis and Chair of the Joint Chiefs General Joseph Dunford. President Trump announced the US withdrawal on May 8, 2018.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> Both cases show commitments made for domestic political reasons narrowing the options available later. That is the mechanism to name in an essay: policy is chosen in front of a broad audience, and the audience does not disappear when the decision moment arrives.

2.3 How Policymaking Is Organized

National Security Act of 1947

- Created the basic bureaucratic organizations, positions and structures still in use; intended to standardize national security policymaking and promote cooperation.
- It was a response to two problems: cooperation failures and interservice rivalry in World War II, and FDR's highly personalized leadership style and lack of clear organization.
- It created the National Security Council, the National Military Establishment (amended in 1949 to become the Department of Defense), the Secretary of Defense, and the Central Intelligence Agency.

The National Security Council

- Designed to promote interagency cooperation and coordination. The president chairs all NSC meetings when present.
- Statutory members: President, Vice President, Secretary of State, Secretary of the Treasury, Secretary of Defense, Secretary of Energy, Director of the Office of Pandemic Preparedness and Response, and such other officers as the President designates.
- Statutory advisers: the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs (principal military adviser to the president and the NSC) and the Director of National Intelligence.
- Formerly included the Director of Mutual Security and the Chair of the National Security Resources Board, both defunct, and the service chiefs.

- Because the president decides who else attends, the NSC looks different from administration to administration. As of 2025 it also includes the Attorney General, Secretary of the Interior, Chief of Staff, National Security Advisor, Secretary of Homeland Security, and the Homeland Security Advisor.

The committee structure

- The Principals Committee is the Cabinet-level senior interagency forum for national security policy issues—where top-level policymaking happens.
- The Deputies Committee, composed of agency deputies, starts implementation and monitors the coordinating committees.
- Policy Coordinating Committees operate at roughly the Assistant Secretary level and implement NSC guidance back inside departments.
- Principals and deputies also act within their own agencies, and much coordination happens informally—for example, presidents having breakfast with members of the team to work through key issues.
- NSC staff: roughly 50 permanent staffers plus others assigned from parent agencies (services, DoD, State). Statute caps the NSC at 200 staffers; debates recur about shrinking it. In recent years it has swelled to much larger sizes, with some arguing that it has come to resemble the same kind of bloated bureaucracy that it was intended to remedy.
- Membership is itself a political fight. Early in the first Trump administration, chief political strategist Steve Bannon was given a seat on the NSC and the Principals Committee while the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs was removed as a mandatory participant—rescinded by a later memo that April.
- Finally, policy is guided by politics. Campaign promises and constituencies shape policy and the decisions that follow, and presidents continue monitoring constituent preferences throughout.

2.4 Policymaking Pitfalls

The ideal process collects information from all available sources, coordinates and distills it, and considers a broad range of options with costs and benefits specified for each. Every pitfall below is a departure from that benchmark.

Breakdowns in information search

- Reliance on a single information channel. Even a source acting in good faith may not have all the facts; at worst the source is compromised. Case: the US embassy and CIA relied heavily on the Shah for intelligence on Iran, which gave a distorted picture of domestic stability—and the Shah suppressed alternative sources.
- A related dynamic: accounts suggest Colin Powell was frozen out of Bush administration deliberations in the immediate aftermath of the September 11 attacks, which prevented him from giving advice.
- Reliance on analogies. Using history to guide policy is reasonable but hazardous, because not all cases are alike even when they look alike. Treating Vietnam as the template for every insurgency produces bad conclusions.
- The Munich analogy is the canonical case: Chamberlain, Hitler and the Sudetenland produce the dubious general conclusion that all diplomatic negotiation is dangerous, ignoring the particulars that distinguish cases. This is problematic on its face due to the fact that the world is overwhelmingly characterized by negotiations. There may be more specific factors that can be used to argue why negotiations with Hitler at this time may have been a mistake, but this should not be confused with a generalizable truism.
- Applied to Iran, the Munich parallel fails on its particulars: the power disparity between the US and Iran is enormous; Iran's goals are not evidently like Germany's, with no clear territorial ambitions requiring regional conquest; Iran is surrounded by wealthy, heavily armed, hostile neighbors; limited strikes are unlikely to be effective and full invasion is not feasible. In the 1930s, by contrast, capabilities were much closer, and Germany capabilities were growing rapidly. The allied powers were also recovering from a devastating global war that had

ended not two decades earlier. However, we have also seen that Iran has been able to utilize its geopolitical advantages to great effect in the 2026 war with the United States. The US still possesses enormous capabilities, but the Trump Administration has largely proven unwilling to more fully engage those capabilities.

- Motivated information search. Policymakers know the conclusion they want and look for information that fits. Doves see opportunities for peace where there are none; hawks see enemies as stronger than they are, because that justifies aggressive policies. The dynamic worsens when advocates of a policy also supply the information.
- Case: Douglas Feith and the Office of Special Plans, set up to provide intelligence aligned with desired policy—specifically supporting the invasion of Iraq. It produced the intelligence "linking" al Qaeda to Iraq, and also ran postwar planning. Second case: intelligence assessments of ISIS and the Taliban coming out of Central Command were alleged to have been manipulated to overstate successes and downplay failures.
- Bureaucratic rivalry can skew assessments. Critics argue Secretary of State Mike Pompeo gave President Trump overly optimistic views of North Korea's willingness to denuclearize, while National Security Advisor John Bolton framed negotiations around the "Libya model"—Gaddafi gave up his WMD program in 2005 and was killed by rebels in 2011 operating with the support or US and NATO air strikes— with the suspicion that he was trying to sabotage talks in favor of a hard line.

Not considering the full range of options

- On the decision side: politicians may not consider every option; some are eliminated immediately as politically undesirable; and bureaucratic officials or advisers may manipulate the menu presented to higher ranking officials. The response to September 11 could have emphasized diplomacy or law enforcement; the Bush administration settled quickly on large-scale military action.
- On the outcome side: politicians may not consider all possible outcomes, for allies as well as adversaries, and may hold vague goals or overly optimistic assessments.

> The 2026 Iran war is the lecture's current illustration. Defense researchers and military planners predicted for decades that Iran would close the Strait of Hormuz, which has proven hard to handle. The administration also appears to have overestimated its influence over Prime Minister Netanyahu's government, repeatedly announcing tentative ceasefires that Israel then said did not bind it. And after claiming that 2025's Operation Midnight Hammer air strikes had eliminated Iran's nuclear threat, officials needed a new justification in 2026—offering at least eleven inconsistent war aims, from eliminating ballistic missile capacity and destroying Iran's navy to controlling airspace, preempting an imminent threat, and regime change. Unclear and inconsistent goals make it impossible to assess progress or what the desired end state goals for a military operation actually are.

Conflicts between policy goals

- Politicians make promises to different constituencies on different issues, those promises conflict, and policymakers must then trade off.
- Tariffs are the worked example. Three justifications have been offered: raising revenue, reshoring lost industries and jobs, and serving as a bargaining tool for better deals.
- While there is historical precedent for using tariffs in these ways, they undercut each other. Raising revenue requires people to keep buying imports, which means you cannot protect domestic industry very well. Reshoring requires tariffs high enough to make imports unattractive—which collapses the revenue. And tariffs used as a short-term bargaining chip, raised and lowered, produce neither steady revenue nor an environment conducive to building domestic industry.
- A second cluster: promises to lower inflation, carry out mass deportations, get tough on trade partners, and cut the federal bureaucracy. Agriculture depends heavily on undocumented labor, so deportations create shortages

that raise prices; tariffs are taxes that raise prices; trade conflict invites retaliation against US agricultural exports; and eliminating USAID cut demand for US agricultural products shipped overseas.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> Conflicting goals are not incompetence in the lecture's telling—they are the predictable potential result of assembling a coalition by promising different things to different groups. Ask what the alternative would have required politically.

3. The Bureaucracy and the State Department

3.1 From Amateurs to Careers

- The executive bureaucracy before World War II was very small. Recall the first lectures: a small country with a small population, small tax base, small diplomatic corps and small military cannot do much.
- The Executive Office of the President was created in 1939.
- Foreign policy activism spurred demand for personnel and expertise. The Depression and World War II are the big drivers, as larger support staff became necessary to manage growing programs.
- Senior administrators up through World War II generally had little government experience. The bureaucracy did not become a career until after the 1940s.
- Across the Cold War, appointees' prior government experience rises steadily, and a higher proportion of appointees have served before—experience becomes both deeper and more widespread. (The data cover secretaries, deputy, under and assistant secretaries at State, Defense and Treasury, plus National Security Advisers and CIA Directors.)
- Education levels rise too: the modal attainment moves from BA to PhD. Meanwhile time spent in the private sector declines in the early Cold War, though it never disappears, and Republican presidents appoint people with somewhat more private sector experience as compared to Democratic presidents.

3.2 What Bureaucracies Are and Do

- Day-to-day management and operations of government; helping formulate policy; providing expertise and advice; coordinating the actions of various bureaucratic actors; executing and implementing policy.

> Functional differentiation: the specialization of different governmental units.

- It operates at every level—State versus Defense, Navy versus Army, artillery versus armor, etc.
- This is key to the modern state, not just the US: government becomes composed of offices more important than their individual holders, each specializing in certain tasks. It accompanies the broader professionalization of fields in the early 20th century.
- A consequence to carry forward: as the federal bureaucracy grows, organizations often stop communicating with one another—which is exactly what coordinating bodies are designed to fix.

3.3 Why Bureaucracies Matter

- Presidents make thousands of appointments, hundreds of them related to foreign policymaking. Direct presidential involvement varies with personal taste, and concentrates on the big three—State, Defense, Treasury. Presidents also rely on professional and epistemic networks to fill most positions.

- Careers can span the whole apparatus. Robert Lovett served as Undersecretary of State, Deputy Secretary of Defense, and Secretary of Defense, and was offered his choice of State, Defense or Treasury by Kennedy. He was a Republican sworn in as Democratic President Truman's Secretary of Defense in September 1951.
- Paul Nitze served as Secretary of the Navy, Assistant Secretary of Defense for International Security Affairs, Director of State's Policy Planning Staff, and Deputy Secretary of Defense—and was principal author of NSC-68.
- Secretary of Defense Chuck Hagel had been a Republic Senator from Nebraska. He was also the first enlisted veteran to serve as Secretary. Most others had military experience, but as commissioned officers.

> Position in the bureaucratic hierarchy does not always match influence. Influence depends on being a principal or a deputy, on issue area, and on prestige. The lecture's paired portraits make the point: Nitze and Wolfowitz, Kennan and Robert Kennedy, Hagel and Kissinger. Be able to explain how someone well below the top of an organization chart can drive policy.

Motivations

- Fulfilling the organization's basic operational mandate or mission.
- Advancing the interests of the organization.
- Fulfilling the responsibilities of the individual position.
- Advancing personal interests and power.

Common problems—know all five

Problem	What it means
Capture	The appointee or organization comes to serve the interests it was meant to regulate or the constituency it serves.
Stove-piping	Information travels up within a single channel and never across, so no one assembles the whole picture.
Groupthink	Consensus-seeking inside a cohesive group suppresses dissent and narrows the options considered.
Turf battles	Organizations fight to protect missions, budgets and jurisdiction rather than to solve the problem.
Slow adaptation	Standard operating procedures persist after the conditions that justified them have changed.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> The unit's second organizing question asks how suboptimal outcomes can arise from good actors following organizational mandates. These five are a big part of the answer. For each, find an example elsewhere in this guide—the Iranian school strike, the Office of Special Plans, the Revolt of the Admirals, the Shah as a single channel.

3.4 The State Department

- The Secretary of State is the chief diplomat of the United States and is supposed to be the president's principal adviser on foreign affairs.
- Responsibilities: expertise and information across policy questions and regions; embassies and diplomats worldwide; and administering immigration and visa policy.

- Governed primarily by Title 22 of the US Code, with charges including democracy promotion, human rights, economic development, environmental issues and US scientific interests.
- A power worth knowing: under Title 8, the Secretary may deem deportable an alien whose presence or activities the Secretary has reasonable ground to believe would have potentially serious adverse foreign policy consequences. This was the basis for denying and cancelling hundreds of student visas in 2025, often over political speech, and has been contested in court repeatedly.
- The current Secretary is Marco Rubio, former US Senator from Florida, elected in 2010, a 2016 presidential candidate, and a member of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee. He had extensive policymaking experience in foreign affairs before being appointed to the position.
- Ambassadors: the rank is relatively new, created in 1893. "Minister" was formerly the highest US diplomatic rank. Ambassadorships go to country and regional experts, but also to political allies—Matthew Barzun, who worked on Obama's campaign and became Ambassador to the UK, is the lecture's example. Some positions go to technocrats and experts, others to political allies.

From first among equals to decline

- State was historically the primary foreign policymaking body and its secretaries were enormously influential. Jefferson, Madison, Monroe, John Quincy Adams, Van Buren and Buchanan all held the office.
- Dean Acheson, Truman's Secretary of State, was targeted during the Red Scare as congressional Republicans claimed communists had infiltrated the government—an episode from which the department's standing never fully recovered.

Five reasons for State's decline:

1. Its basic organizational mandate.
2. Its organizational structure.
3. The qualities emphasized in Foreign Service Officers.
4. Gaps between Washington and local offices.
5. The growth of alternative organizations and offices—above all the NSC and the White House staff.

- The deeper problem: State's mission is diplomacy, which means talking to and making deals with people who may be unpopular at home. Its work is hard to see, takes a long time to pay off, and produces results that are difficult to detect. Military force offers the illusion of seriousness and immediate results—though, as the 2026 Iran war shows, force does not always solve the underlying problem, and may exacerbate it.
- The contrasting pairs the lecture shows—Rogers and Kissinger, Powell and Rumsfeld—are cases where the Secretary of State was eclipsed by the National Security Adviser or the Secretary of Defense.
- Evidence on the other side: the JCPOA succeeded in eliminating Iran's capacity to produce nuclear weapons, and was broadly supported by Gulf states, with Saudi Arabia more skeptical but publicly supportive. Republican opposition stemmed from domestic politics, not allied objections.
- Party ID and ideology can explain some of this, too: Some individuals tend to be much more skeptical of the efficacy of diplomatic power and negotiations. They see military power and "hard" power as being the most effective tools available to the executive.

Example: USAID

- Created by the Foreign Assistance Act of 1961, consolidating previously existing foreign aid programs and administering civilian foreign aid and development assistance.
- Dismantled by the Trump administration's DOGE cuts in 2025.

- The Act's general policy section declares that American liberty, prosperity and security are best sustained in a community of nations respecting civil and economic rights, and commits the US to helping people in developing countries eliminate hunger, poverty, illness and ignorance.
- Think back to Norris—Foreign aid was a tool to advance US interests, but it was also intimately connected with basic improvements in quality of life for people abroad.
- Gap between public perceptions and reality—most people think the United States spends far more on foreign aid than it actually does. In reality it has been a very small proportion of the federal budget, but public opinion polls often reveal public estimates that are exponentially higher than actual figures.

4. The Defense Department and the Military

4.1 Before 1947: Two Departments, One War

- The military was two separate, independent entities: the Department of War (Army) and the Department of the Navy. Both were small and oriented toward external threats. But also think back to the first part of the course and recall how the definition of "external" has shifted over time.
- Henry Stimson and Frank Knox ran War and Navy during World War II. Both were Republicans, and both reported directly to Roosevelt.
- Independent services produced coordination problems, and Stimson and others criticized FDR's administrative abilities—poor at giving direction and keeping subordinates organized.
- Truman: "We must never fight another war the way we fought the last two. I have the feeling that if the Army and the Navy had fought our enemies as hard as they fought each other, the war would have ended much earlier."
- Stimson called the Joint Chiefs "an imperfect instrument of top-level decision," because "it remained incapable of enforcing a decision against the will of any one of its members." Marshall said "the lack of real unity has handicapped the successful conduct of the war."

4.2 The National Security Act of 1947 and Its Politics

- Created the National Military Establishment, which became the Department of Defense in 1949.
- Made the Army Air Corps an independent Air Force.
- Brought Army, Navy, Air Force and Marine Corps under one organization with a single civilian secretary.
- The politics were tough. Army leaders wanted the Air Corps out, arguing it would corrupt the Army's traditional mission of overwhelming ground combat capability.
- Navy Secretary James Forrestal opposed unification, fearing the Navy would be reduced to a transportation role and the Marine Corps stripped and folded into the Army—particularly since the Air Force now had nuclear weapons and the Army and Navy did not. Later amendments protected the Navy's air wing and the Marine Corps.
- Forrestal then became the first Secretary of Defense, and the position was initially weak. He could do little to override the chiefs and the military departments. Truman wanted to cap the FY1949 budget at $10 billion, but the service chiefs went around Forrestal and got Congress to approve more. Truman wanted $14.4 billion for FY1950; Forrestal and the JCS prepared plans ranging from $14.4 to $18 billion. Forrestal resigned March 28, 1949.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> Forrestal is the clearest case in the course of an official defeated by the organization he nominally led. Ask what institutional resources he lacked—and then check which of them Goldwater-Nichols later supplied.

4.3 How the Department Is Organized

Component	What it is
Office of the Secretary of Defense (OSD)	The main civilian component, overseeing every aspect of the department. Military officers do work within it.
Military Departments	Army, Navy, Air Force. The Marine Corps sits within the Department of the Navy; the Space Force within the Department of the Air Force.
Joint Chiefs of Staff	Senior uniformed advisers; equip, train and organize the services. NOT in the operational chain of command. They also oversee the Joint Staff, which helps to coordinate policies and plans between the services, OSD, and others.
Combatant Commands	Oversee forces from all branches in a geographic or functional area of responsibility; plan and execute operations; answer directly to the President and the Secretary of Defense.

Goldwater-Nichols Act of 1986

- The greatest reorganization of the US military since 1947.
- Removed the Joint Chiefs from the operational chain of command. Command now runs from the President to the Secretary of Defense to the combatant commanders.
- Created the Vice Chairman of the Joint Chiefs.
- The rationale: because combatant commanders command forces from every branch, they were expected to be less parochial than service chiefs.
- Coordination problems persisted. The (possibly apocryphal) Grenada story has an Army officer using an AT&T calling card and a payphone to reach air support because the Army and Air Force were not on the same frequency. Services also buy similar but non-interchangeable equipment, which helps preserve service independence by making consolidation enormously costly.

The Joint Chiefs and the combatant commands

- The JCS equip, train and organize the services; serve as senior uniformed advisers to the President, NSC and Congress; guide development of weapons systems, technology and force structure; and set routine administrative policy.
- The Chairman is the highest ranking uniformed officer. The JCS is mostly administrative—though planning, recruitment and weapons systems obviously bear on war-fighting.
- Combatant commanders are more directly responsible for war planning and fighting, and advise the President and Congress on operations. David Petraeus at CENTCOM is one of the best-known recent example.
- The Coast Guard is not a member of the JCS because it falls under Homeland Security. The Space Force, established by the 2020 National Defense Authorization Act, is the first new service since 1947, and sits under the Department of the Air Force.

4.4 Who Can Hold These Jobs

- Secretary of Defense: a political appointment subject to Senate confirmation, responsible for the organization of the armed forces, the development of national defense strategy, and reporting to the President and Congress.
- Statutory requirements (Title 10, Section 113): must be appointed "from civilian life." A former officer below one-star rank must be seven years removed from active duty; an officer at O-7 or above must be ten years removed. This is why Mattis and Austin each required a waiver.

- Backgrounds vary widely. Lloyd Austin was career Army, retiring a four-star general, and the first African American Secretary of Defense. Ashton Carter was a physicist. Harold Brown earned a PhD in nuclear physics at 21. Chuck Hagel served as a sergeant in Vietnam and then developed policy expertise over years in the Senate.
- Pete Hegseth, the current Secretary, is a retired Army major and former Fox News commentator with military experience but none at the policy or strategic level.
- The lecture poses the debate directly: is a military background necessary, or even desirable, in a Secretary of Defense?

The Chairman and Title 10, Section 152

- The Chairman serves two years beginning in odd-numbered years, and may be reappointed to one additional two-year term.
- Eligibility: the officer must have served as Vice Chairman, as a service chief of staff, or as commander of a unified or specified combatant command.
- The President may waive these requirements in the national interest.
- The Chairman is a general or admiral and outranks all other officers, but "may not exercise military command over the Joint Chiefs of Staff or any of the armed forces."
- Dan Caine's appointment broke the pattern: Trump and Hegseth fired his predecessor, Charles Q. Brown; Caine had retired in 2024 as a lieutenant general and had not served in the statutorily required roles. Presidential waiver required, asserting that Caine's appointment was vital to the national security interests of the United States.
- Senior commissioned officers require Congressional confirmation, but Senate holds can also paralyze the system. Normally promotions are voted on in bundles because there are so many officers. Senator Tommy Tuberville's blanket hold on promotions over a DoD policy on travel for reproductive care forced the Senate to break the Chairman, the Marine Commandant and the Army Chief of Staff into separate votes. Chairman Jack Reed noted that processing the 260-plus pending nominations individually would take 27 days of round-the-clock work, or 84 days at eight hours a day, leaving key roles unfilled or officers doing two jobs at once.

4.5 The Military as a Political Institution

> The core claim: the military is inherently political, and managing it is inherently political. Civilian control of the military IS a political arrangement. Keeping the military "apolitical"—more accurately, non-partisan—is itself a fundamentally political question. Know the distinction between non-political and non-partisan cold; the lecture lists it as a key question.

> The puzzle: how do we "reconcile a military strong enough to do anything the civilians ask with a military subordinate enough to do only what civilians authorize?" (Feaver 2003, 2)

Civil-military relations has three core parts:

1. How the civilian population and the military relate to one another.
2. Military actors intervening in civilian political processes.
3. Civilians politicizing the military.

Party economics and force structure

- In the Cold War years Republicans tend to enact capital-friendly policies and Democrats labor-friendly ones, and those macroeconomic preferences carry into military policy: Democrats have preferred a labor-intensive force structure, Republicans a capital-intensive one.
- The relationship has weakened over time since Fordham first identified it—note the link back to the Exam 1 material on Fordham and defense spending.
- Military personnel have their own preferences. Survey data show a large increase in Republican self-identification among officers, mostly at the expense of independents.
- Does that mean the military is becoming more conservative? Not necessarily. Democratic self-identification is mostly stable with some decline, and underlying conservative orientation may be stable while party ID simply catches up to it. The concern is different: open identification with one party risks the professionalization of the military.

When conflict spills into the open

- The Revolt of the Admirals (1949). Rooted in interservice rivalry and unification, with the Navy fearing that the rise of the Air Force and strategic bombing would leave it vulnerable. Truman wanted an FY1950 budget of $15 billion; the services together calculated they needed $29 billion. Secretary of Defense Louis Johnson halted the Navy's supercarrier program on April 23, 1949 without consulting Navy Secretary John Sullivan, who resigned in protest. Navy leaders, active and retired, attacked the civilian leadership, the Army and the Air Force in House Armed Services Committee hearings.
- General Omar Bradley's response called the Navy leaders "fancy Dans who won't hit the line" unless they could call the signals, and said the public airing of grievances by officers who would not accept lawful decisions had "done infinite harm to our national defense."
- Marine Commandant Clifton Cates, excluded from the 1948 Key West conference on restructuring, testified that budget priorities and the other services were destroying the Marine Corps, backing the Navy while pressing for formal Marine representation on the JCS—which did not come until the 1970s.
- Eric Shinseki and Donald Rumsfeld (2003). Officers try to avoid political entanglement, but that is hard when the president and Congress both demand information that may contradict executive policy. Pressed by Senator Carl Levin before the Iraq invasion, Shinseki finally said "several hundred thousand" troops would be needed, contradicting Rumsfeld and Cheney's insistence that US forces would be greeted as liberators and postwar stabilization would be easy.

Politicization from the civilian side

- Retired officers have become valued political symbols. Michael Flynn appeared with candidate Trump in 2016; John Allen spoke at the Democratic convention the same year. Both were later investigated for lying to the FBI about foreign contacts and lobbying for foreign governments. This just helps to show that extensive military experience is not synonymous with good decision making.
- The problem with endorsements: they reinforce the perception that civilian leaders require military approval to be legitimate, and they shift foreign policy's center of gravity toward the military—which knows little about most areas of foreign policy, while civilian experts who do lack the weight that uniforms carry.
- Lafayette Square, June 1, 2020. Peaceful protesters were forcibly dispersed so the president could walk to St. John's Church for a photo op, accompanied by Attorney General Barr, Secretary of Defense Esper and Chairman Milley. Both Milley and Esper later distanced themselves.
- The backlash was unusual: two prominent retired figures—former Chairman Mike Mullen and former Secretary of Defense James Mattis—published Atlantic op-eds on June 2 and 3, 2020 explicitly condemning a sitting president. This was the first time Mattis had spoken out publicly since leaving the Trump Administration.

Current Events Example: Recruiting, "woke" critiques, and what the evidence shows

- A recurring claim links recruiting shortfalls over the last several years to a "woke" military. The DoD Youth Survey data cut against the premise that people join for ideological reasons: 43% of those surveyed listed pay and benefits as a primary reason, the largest single category.
- On whether DEI training crowds out war-fighting training, Sergeant Major of the Army Michael Grinston testified in March 2022 that basic training included one hour of equal opportunity training against 92 hours of rifle marksmanship, and that One Station Unit Training included 165 hours of marksmanship against the same single hour.
- Link this to the Krebs and Ralston reading: What factors tend to drive military service decisions? Individual service members often cite benefits like pay, medical benefits, education funding, etc., while family members often cite patriotism and a desire to serve.

Current Events Example: The 2025 firings

- An unusually large group of senior officers were removed: Chairman C.Q. Brown; CNO Lisa Franchetti; Coast Guard Commandant Linda Fagan; Air Force Chief of Staff David Allvin; SOUTHCOM Commander Alvin Holsey; NSA Director and CYBERCOM Commander Timothy Haugh; Air Force Vice Chief James Slife; the Air Force and Army Judge Advocates General; and DIA Director Jeffrey Kruse.
- The stated and reported reasons vary—Brown over his comments on race and military service and his association with DEI; Franchetti amid Hegseth's declaration that new leaders would focus on "deterring, fighting, and winning wars"; Fagan ostensibly over the southern border and handling of sexual assault cases within the Coast Guard, with reporting pointing to DEI issues; Allvin seemingly linked to opposition to strikes against boats in the Caribbean; Kruse after DIA's preliminary report found the Midnight Hammer Fordo strike set Iran's program back only a few months rather than completely destroying.
- The JAG firings worried civil-military relations experts most. JAGs ensure commanders and personnel follow the law, advise on legal questions, prosecute and defend courts-martial, and investigate potential violations. Hegseth said he wanted "lawyers who give sound constitutional advice and don't exist to attempt to be roadblocks," and in his book referred to JAGs as "jagoffs." The fear was that this reduces constraints on the executive and removes impediments to getting personnel to follow potentially illegal orders.

> **THINK ABOUT**
> Put the Kruse firing next to the motivated-information-search material in Section 2.4 and the school strike in Section 1.3. The same pattern recurs: when the people whose job is to supply inconvenient information are removed, the information stops arriving—and the failures that follow look like accidents.

5. The Readings

5.1 Lupton (2017)—Military Experience and Congressional Oversight

- Full citation: Danielle L. Lupton. 2017. "Out of the Service, Into the House: Military Experience and Congressional War Oversight." Political Research Quarterly 70(2): 327–339.
- The question: does prior military service change how members of Congress oversee the use of force? Read for the direction of the effect and the mechanism she proposes.
- Connection to lecture: Section 1.6 lists oversight among Congress's real powers and notes a long decline in its use. Lupton asks who inside Congress actually exercises it, which turns an institutional question into a question about individual legislators.

- Tie it to the veteran-background debate in Section 4.4 about Secretaries of Defense: both ask what military experience does to a civilian official's judgment.

5.2 Weissman (2017)—Congress and War

- Full citation: Stephen R. Weissman. 2017. "Congress and War: How the House and the Senate Can Reclaim Their Role." Foreign Affairs 96(1): 132–145.
- The argument: Congress has abdicated its constitutional role in decisions about war, and the piece proposes how it might reclaim that role.
- The word to notice is "reclaim." It presumes the power was never lost, only unused—the same position the lecture takes in Section 1.2.
- Pair with the War Powers Resolution material. Be ready to say which of Weissman's proposed fixes address the real obstacle, given that the 1973 Act is rarely invoked and never enforced.

5.3 Miller (2016)—Graveyard of Analogies

- Full citation: Paul D. Miller. 2016. "Graveyard of Analogies: The Use and Abuse of History for the War in Afghanistan." Journal of Strategic Studies 39(3): 446–476.
- The subject: how historical analogies—Afghanistan as the "graveyard of empires," the Soviet experience, Vietnam—were used and misused in reasoning about the Afghanistan war.
- This is the assigned reading for the policymaking lecture and maps directly onto Section 2.4's analogies pitfall. Lecture supplies Munich and Vietnam; Miller supplies the extended case.
- Read for the general claim: analogies are not avoidable and not simply bad. The question is what makes a particular analogy apt, and what tests a policymaker should apply before relying on one.

5.4 Krebs and Ralston (2022)—Patriotism or Paychecks

- Full citation: Ronald R. Krebs and Robert Ralston. 2022. "Patriotism or Paychecks: Who Believes What About Why Soldiers Serve." Armed Forces & Society 48(1): 25–48.
- The finding highlighted in lecture: a large gulf between respondents with military experience and their families. Veterans of the all-volunteer force and active duty members are more likely to acknowledge that the market matters in decisions to serve; their families are more prone to deny it.
- It fits the DoD Youth Survey evidence in Section 4.5, where 43% named pay and benefits as a primary reason for joining.
- Why it matters for this unit: if the public misunderstands why people serve, public debate about recruiting—including the "woke military" explanation—is built on a false premise, and so are the policy fixes proposed. Misunderstanding the motivations of those who serve also acts to erode trust in the military as a non-partisan institution.

5.5 The Policy Readings

Reading	What to take from it
CFR, Revitalizing the State Department (CSR 89)	The diagnosis of State's decline and the proposed remedies. Compare its list of causes with the five in Section 3.4.
NYT, "How Marco Rubio Is Running Venezuela From Afar"	A current case of how policy is actually made and who makes it—read against the lecture's claim that authority has migrated from the department to a small circle around the president.

Reading	What to take from it
The War Horse, women in combat roles	A decade of women in combat roles, and the reopening of the debate at the Pentagon. Connects to the standards-and-"lethality" framing behind the 2025 firings.
Military.com, "The Recruiting Surge Was Engineered"	Whether the recruiting recovery was produced by policy rather than sentiment, and whether it survives a war with Iran. Test it against Krebs and Ralston.
Military.com, "Could the US Bring Back the Draft?"	Who would be called first and who qualifies—the manpower question underneath force structure.
Military.com, renaming DoD to "Department of War"	Why a name matters: the 1947 unification created "Defense" deliberately. Ask what the proposed change signals about mission.

6. Glossary

Term	Definition
Institutions	The rules governing how we govern—who holds which powers, when, and how power is allocated. Institutions have no preferences; only actors do.
Separated institutions sharing powers	Neustadt's formulation: the Constitution divides institutions but distributes overlapping powers among them, so each depends on the others.
Executive Office of the President (EOP)	Created 1939. Houses advisers (including the National Security Adviser) who are not subject to Senate confirmation.
Treaty	Negotiated by the executive, consented to by two-thirds of senators present, ratified by the president.
Sole executive agreement	An international agreement concluded by the president or executive agents alone, entering force on signature.
Congressional-executive agreement	An agreement approved by joint resolution, requiring only majority support in both chambers.
Political agreement	A set of political commitments that is not legally binding and may not even be signed—the JCPOA.
Fast track	Delegated negotiating authority under which Congress votes up or down with no amendments; originates with the RTAA of 1934.
AUMF	Authorization for the Use of Military Force. The 2001 and 2002 AUMFs have supported operations in dozens of countries under three presidents.
War Powers Resolution (1973)	Requires consultation, a 48-hour report, and withdrawal within 60 days (90 if in danger) absent authorization; permits Congress to end a deployment by concurrent resolution.
First-mover advantage	The president can deploy force before Congress acts, leaving Congress to respond to a fait accompli.
Information asymmetry	The executive receives military and intelligence information first, through the chain of command, and briefs Congress afterward.
Policy	Plans for broad classes of future contingencies.
Decision	Choices for dealing with immediate problems.
Massive retaliation	Eisenhower's New Look doctrine of deterring aggression with the threat of overwhelming nuclear response.

Term	Definition
Salami tactics	Small incremental incursions that fall below the threshold at which a massive response is credible.
National Security Act of 1947	Created the NSC, the National Military Establishment (DoD in 1949), the Secretary of Defense and the CIA.
Principals Committee	The Cabinet-level senior interagency forum for national security policy; the Deputies Committee and Policy Coordinating Committees sit below it.
Motivated information search	Seeking information that confirms a preferred policy conclusion; worsened when policy advocates also supply the information.
Functional differentiation	The specialization of governmental units, with offices more important than their individual holders.
Capture	An appointee or organization coming to serve the interests it exists to regulate.
Stove-piping	Information moving up a single channel and never across, so no one assembles the whole picture.
Groupthink	Consensus-seeking in a cohesive group that suppresses dissent and narrows options.
Goldwater-Nichols Act (1986)	Removed the JCS from the operational chain of command, created the Vice Chairman, and ran command from President to D to combatant commanders.
Combatant command	A command overseeing forces from all services in a geographic or functional area of responsibility, answering to the President and Secretary of Defense.
Civilian control of the military	A political arrangement, not a neutral fact—and the subject of Feaver's puzzle about strength versus subordination.
Non-political vs. non-partisan	The military cannot be non-political, since its existence, composition, and management are inherently political questions; what is actually sought is non-partisanship.
Judge Advocate General (JAG)	Military lawyers who ensure personnel follow the law, advise commanders, prosecute and defend courts-martial, and investigate violations.

7. People and Positions

Person	Why they matter
Richard Neustadt	Scholar of the presidency. "Separated institutions sharing powers."
Charles Bohlen / John Tower	Contested confirmations—one confirmed 74–13 under McCarthy's attacks, one rejected in 1989.
Pete Hegseth	Confirmed 51–50 on the VP's tie-break; current Secretary of Defense; subject of impeachment efforts in 2026.
Thomas Massie	Moved to impeach Hegseth, September 2026.
Cordell Hull	Secretary of State. Negotiated tariff reductions under the RTAA of 1934.
Henry Kissinger / Zbigniew Brzezinski / Condoleezza Rice	National Security Advisers—the rise of the EOP at State's expense.
Lyndon Johnson / Robert McNamara	Gulf of Tonkin; first-mover advantage and information asymmetry in practice.

Person	Why they matter
James Baker	Secretary of State. 1995 testimony urging a Republican Congress not to constrain a Democratic president's flexibility.
Donald Rumsfeld	Secretary of Defense. "The army you have"; the light-force doctrine; the Shinseki confrontation.
Douglas Feith	Office of Special Plans—motivated information search.
John Bolton / Mike Pompeo	Bureaucratic rivalry and skewed assessments over North Korea.
Robert Lovett / Paul Nitze	Careers spanning State, Defense and Treasury; influence beyond formal position.
Dean Acheson	Secretary of State targeted during the Red Scare.
Marco Rubio	Current Secretary of State.
Henry Stimson / Frank Knox	Secretaries of War and Navy in WWII; the coordination failures behind the 1947 Act.
James Forrestal	Opposed unification, then became the first—and institutionally weak—Secretary of Defense.
Omar Bradley / Clifton Cates	The Revolt of the Admirals and the Marine Corps' fight for standing.
Eric Shinseki	Contradicted Rumsfeld on troop requirements for Iraq. Difficulty of bureaucratic actors who owe loyalty to two separate institutions.
Mark Milley / Mark Esper	Lafayette Square and the subsequent distancing. Questions concerning the appearance of the military being used against domestic political opponents.
Mike Mullen / James Mattis	June 2020 Atlantic op-eds condemning a sitting president.
Dan Caine	Appointed Chairman without having served in the statutorily required roles.
C.Q. Brown / Lisa Franchetti / Timothy Haugh / Jeffrey Kruse	The 2025 removals of senior officers.
Tommy Tuberville	Blanket hold on military promotions in response to DoD policy over personnel access to reproductive care.
Peter Feaver	The civil-military relations puzzle.

8. Statutes and Milestones

Year	Development
1893	Rank of ambassador created; "minister" had been the highest US diplomatic rank
1934	Reciprocal Trade Agreements Act—tariff authority delegated to the executive
1939	Executive Office of the President created
1947	National Security Act—NSC, National Military Establishment, Secretary of Defense, CIA; independent Air Force
1949	National Military Establishment becomes the Department of Defense; Revolt of the Admirals; Forrestal resigns
1961	Foreign Assistance Act creates USAID
1964	Gulf of Tonkin Resolution

Year	Development
1967–1972	SALT I negotiations; ABM Treaty
1973	War Powers Resolution
1986	Goldwater-Nichols Act
2001 / 2002	AUMF (September 11) and AUMF (Iraq)
2015–2016	JCPOA concluded (July 2015) and implemented (January 2016)
2018	US withdraws from the JCPOA
2020	Space Force established by the National Defense Authorization Act; Lafayette Square
2025	USAID dismantled; removals of senior military officers; Hegseth confirmed 51–50
2026	Iran war; impeachment efforts against Hegseth; war powers votes in both chambers

9. Practice Questions

9.1 Identification

For each: what it is, when, and why it matters.

1. Separated institutions sharing powers
2. Executive Office of the President
3. Sole executive agreement
4. Reciprocal Trade Agreements Act of 1934
5. The ABM Treaty
6. The JCPOA
7. Gulf of Tonkin Resolution
8. The 2001 AUMF
9. War Powers Resolution of 1973
10. Issue linkage
11. The New Look
12. Salami tactics
13. National Security Act of 1947
14. The Principals Committee
15. Office of Special Plans
16. Functional differentiation
17. Stove-piping
18. Goldwater-Nichols Act of 1986
19. Combatant command
20. Revolt of the Admirals

9.2 Short Answer

1. Why does the lecture insist that institutions do not fight? What does that reframing change about how we explain congressional inaction on war powers?
2. Explain the difference between the Senate consenting to a treaty and the president ratifying it. Why does the distinction matter?
3. Identify two selection effects in this unit—one in appointments, one in treaties—and explain what each does to the numbers we observe.
4. Why does the creation of the EOP in 1939 matter for congressional oversight?
5. List the four presidential advantages in the use of force and give one concrete example of each.
6. The War Powers Resolution has never been enforced. What does Congress get out of it anyway?
7. Distinguish policy from decision, and explain how policy constrains later decisions. Use Rumsfeld in 2004 or Trump and the JCPOA.
8. Name the three breakdowns in information search and give the lecture's case for each.
9. Why did the Secretary of Defense position begin so weak in 1947, and what did Goldwater-Nichols change about the chain of command?
10. Explain the difference between a non-political military and a non-partisan one, and why the lecture says only one is possible.
11. What do the DoD Youth Survey and Krebs and Ralston together imply about the "woke military" explanation for recruiting shortfalls?
12. Explain how the concept of the all-volunteer force can act as a constraint on foreign policy adventurism.

9.3 Essay

1. "Congress has not lost its foreign policy powers; it has declined to use them." Evaluate this claim using the appointment power, the power of the purse, oversight, and the War Powers Resolution. What would it take to show the opposite?
2. Trace the migration of foreign policy authority from Senate-confirmed officials to the Executive Office of the President. What explains it, and what are the consequences for accountability?
3. Using the Iranian school strike of February 2026 as an example case, diagnose the failure at every level this unit covers: presidential direction, bureaucratic process, information flow, and civil-military relations. Which failure was most decisive?
4. Policy instruments trade constraint against flexibility. Using treaties, executive agreements and the JCPOA, argue whether presidents have gained or lost by moving toward less binding instruments.
5. "Suboptimal foreign policy outcomes often result from good-faith actors faithfully following their organizational mandates, not from bad actors doing bad things." Defend or attack this claim with at least three cases.
6. Why has the State Department declined relative to the Defense Department and the NSC? Rank the five explanations from lecture and defend your ordering.
7. In what senses is the US military a political institution? Distinguish politicization by military actors from politicization by civilians, and assess which poses the greater risk to civilian control.
8. Both the Revolt of the Admirals (1949) and the senior officer removals of 2025 involve open conflict between uniformed leaders and civilian authority. Compare them. What does the comparison reveal about what has and has not changed in civil-military relations?

9. Explain how historical analogies can serve to mislead policymakers and contribute to poor decision-making. What are some of Miller's recommendations for how history can be used to better inform policymaking choices?

10. Common Pitfalls

- Writing that Congress and the president "clash as institutions." Institutions allocate power; actors have preferences. The lecture rejects this phrasing explicitly.
- Saying the Senate ratifies treaties. It consents; the president ratifies.
- Treating the JCPOA as a treaty, or even as an executive agreement. It is a non-binding political agreement, and it was not signed.
- Assuming the Joint Chiefs command forces. Since 1986 they are advisers outside the operational chain of command.
- Confusing the Office of the Secretary of Defense (civilian leadership) with the Joint Staff (uniformed advisers) or with the combatant commands (operations).
- Treating "apolitical military" as achievable. Civilian control is itself a political arrangement; the attainable goal is non-partisanship.
- Explaining bad policy by bad people. Most of this unit explains bad outcomes through mandates, incentives and information flows.
- Reading low confirmation-failure rates as evidence of deference. Nominees who would lose usually withdraw first.
- Giving a date without a significance. On identifications, significance is worth more than the date.